



The SR.N1 hovercraft near Calais, France

1959

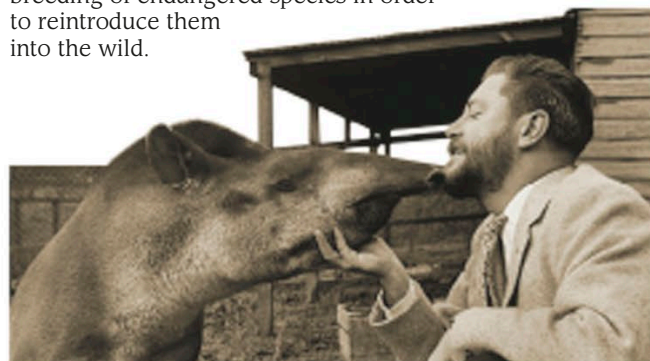
First working hovercraft

The Saunders-Roe Nautical 1 (SR.N1) hovercraft, invented by English engineer Christopher Cockerell, made its first English Channel crossing from Calais in France to Dover in the UK. Powered by a piston engine, a large fan raised the craft up on a cushion of air, enabling it to travel with low friction over both land and water.

1959

Zoo as a conservation tool

British naturalist Gerald Durrell created a zoological park at Les Augrès manor house on the island of Jersey. The zoo was designed to focus on the conservation and breeding of endangered species in order to reintroduce them into the wild.



Gerald Durrell at Jersey Zoo with a tapir

1959

Human ancestor

British paleontologist Mary Leakey discovered the skull of an ancestor of modern humans in Tanzania's Olduvai Gorge. Named *Paranthropus boisei*—and also called *Australopithecus boisei*—it was dated as 1.75 million years old and later proposed to be one of the first human ancestors to use stone tools.



1960

1958

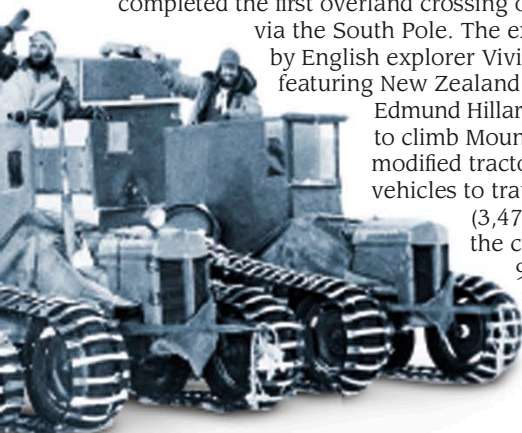
Integrated circuits

American inventors Jack Kilby and Robert Noyce independently developed integrated circuits. These small wafers of material such as silicon or germanium contain an entire electronic circuit and all its components.

1958

Overland crossing of Antarctica

The Commonwealth Trans-Antarctic Expedition completed the first overland crossing of Antarctica via the South Pole. The expedition, led by English explorer Vivian Fuchs and featuring New Zealand mountaineer Edmund Hillary—the first man to climb Mount Everest—used modified tractors and other vehicles to travel 2,158 miles (3,473 km) across the continent in 99 days.



Hillary and team at the South Pole

1906–1992

GRACE HOPPER

This American programming pioneer worked on the Harvard Mark 1 and Univac computers before helping to develop the first practical compiler—a program that converts understandable English commands into code that instructs computers.

**COBOL creator**

Hopper stands in front of a bank of computer tape drives used for storing data. She played a major part in the creation of the easy-to-use computer language called COBOL-60 (Common Business-Oriented Language). Variants of COBOL continue to run thousands of business, traffic management, and banking systems.